

{PROXY}Maze'26

Challenge 2 - Participant Guide

25 teams enter. 10 pitch on July 12. This is how it works.
Torch Labs Software | Grand Final: July 12, 2026

1. What Is Challenge 2

You made it through the 24-hour technical filter. The top 25 teams are here. Challenge 2 is the build phase.

You pick a problem in the real world. You build a proxy-powered product that solves it. Then you pitch that product in front of a panel of judges on July 12.

The competition runs in five stages. Proposals are open to all 25 teams. The top 10 move through to the video submission and the Grand Final. There are no wildcards.

One rule that does not change across any track: proxies must be load-bearing. A judge will ask why you cannot build this without proxies. Your answer needs to be immediate and obvious. If you cannot answer that question, go back to the problem.

2. Stages and Key Dates

Five stages across eight weeks. Every team starts at Stage 1. The cut to Stage 2 happens after proposal review.

Stage	Teams	Window	What happens	Deadline
Stage 1	25 teams	May 14 - May 31	All 25 teams submit a proposal	May 31
Stage 2	10 teams	June 7	Top 10 shortlisted and announced	June 7
Stage 3	10 teams	June 7 - June 21	Top 10 submit elevator pitch video	June 21
Stage 4	10 teams	July 12	Grand Final: live demo and pitch. Most Popular Award announced.	July 12

May 31 and July 12 are confirmed dates. All other dates may be adjusted. Watch the official channels for updates.

3. The Four Tracks

Every team chooses one track before submitting a proposal. You cannot switch after submission.

Read all four tracks before you decide. The teams that do best are the ones that picked the track matching how they naturally think, not the one that sounds most impressive on paper.

Track	What kind of problem	Simple example	Why proxies are central
Track 1 The API Gap	A website holds data businesses need, but it has no public API and will never build one.	Pulling live fuel prices from petrol station websites and returning them as a clean JSON feed for logistics apps.	Most data-rich sites block datacenter IPs. Residential rotation is the only way to get consistent access at scale.
Track 2 Give AI Eyes	An AI agent needs to browse the live web reliably to do its job, but gets blocked without a proxy layer.	An AI that takes a company name, visits its live website and LinkedIn, and returns a structured profile for a recruiter.	Sites block automated traffic. Without residential proxies, the agent fails on real targets within minutes.
Track 3 One Workflow, Fully Automated	Someone in an industry repeats the same manual task across multiple websites every day.	Insurance brokers check 8 carrier portals for quotes manually. A tool does it in under 2 minutes using sticky proxy sessions.	Portal sites detect repeated logins from the same IP. Sticky residential sessions are what keeps the workflow from breaking.
Track 4 Vertical Intelligence Layer	Practitioners in one industry have to visit 10+ sites to get the information they need to make a decision.	A daily dashboard for garment buyers showing fabric prices, shipping costs, and compliance updates pulled from 15 live sources.	Each source blocks automated access differently. Multi-source aggregation at scale requires residential and ISP proxies across the pool.

How to approach track selection

There are two valid approaches. Both work. Pick whichever suits how your team thinks.

Approach A: Pick a track first, then find the problem

If you already have a feel for one track, start there. Then go out and find a specific problem inside that space. Talk to people. Look for the version of the problem that has a real cost attached to it.

Example: you like Track 1. You talk to a logistics company and find out they manually check fuel prices on three different websites every morning to calculate delivery costs. That is your problem. The API you build pulls those prices automatically and returns them as clean JSON.

Approach B: Find a real problem first, then find the track

If you have contacts in an industry, or you already know a painful workflow, start with the problem. Go deep on it. Confirm it is real and that someone would pay to solve it. Then look at the four tracks and find which one your solution fits under.

Example: you know a friend who works in insurance and spends two hours a week checking competitor pricing across five different carrier websites. That pain is real. The automation you build fits under Track 3.

Either approach is fine. What is not fine is picking a track because it sounds technical, then reverse-engineering a problem to fit it. Judges can tell the difference.

The proxy rule applies to all four tracks

Regardless of which track you choose, your product must require proxies to function. The four valid reasons are:

- The target site blocks datacenter IPs, so residential rotation is required for reliable access.
- The data differs by location, so geo-targeted proxies are needed to capture local pricing, inventory, or content.
- The workflow needs sustained sessions across many requests that a single IP cannot maintain.
- Anti-bot systems detect repeated access from the same IP, and rotation is the only way to keep throughput up.

If none of these apply to your product, your proxy usage is decorative. Decorative proxy usage costs points on the rubric.

4. Stage 1 - Proposal Submission

All 25 teams submit a proposal. The window opens May 14 and closes May 31. Late submissions are not reviewed.

The proposal is a 2-page PDF covering your problem, your product, why proxies are necessary, and whether your team can actually build it by July 12.

Format

- A4, maximum 2 pages
- Font 10.5pt or 11pt, single or 1.15 line spacing
- PDF only. File name: your_team_name.pdf

Required sections

Section 1: Team and track

Team name, member names, and which of the four tracks you chose.

Section 2: Problem statement

What industry are you targeting? What is the specific workflow, data gap, or access problem? Who faces it? Why is it painful, expensive, or slow? What happens if nobody solves it?

Section 3: Proposed solution

What are you building? What will a user be able to do with it? What does the output look like: an API, a dashboard, a report, an automation? What is the core value for the user?

Section 4: Why proxies are needed

Why does this not work with a normal HTTP request? What breaks without proxies? Which proxy type will you use, residential or ISP or both? Will you need rotation, sticky sessions, or geo-targeting? What failure modes do you expect?

Section 5: Technical build plan

Your stack, data collection method, proxy integration approach, storage if any, AI usage if any. What will be working on July 12?

Section 6: Business case

Who is the paying customer? Why would they pay? How much? What is your pricing model? What does a Torch Labs proxy cost versus expected revenue? What are they replacing today?

Section 7: Scope, timeline, and proxy requirements

What will be done by July 12? What is out of scope? What are the biggest technical risks?

You must also state two things clearly:

- Which proxy product category you need: residential proxies, ISP proxies, or both.
- Whether you need additional support from Torch Labs, for example help with proxy integration, session configuration, rotation logic, or geo-targeting. If yes, describe what you need specifically.

How proposals are scored

Criterion	What judges look for	Weight
Problem quality	Is the problem real and specific? Can you name the industry, the role, and what it costs in time or money? Vague problems score low. A named customer with a clear cost scores high.	High
Product potential	Could this become a business after the hackathon? Is there a market? Would someone pay? Judges look for ideas that survive beyond demo day.	High
Proxy usage	Proxies must be architecturally central. Not just mentioned. Not just faster. Remove the proxy layer and the product should stop working.	High
Team feasibility	Can your team actually build this by July 12? Be honest about scope. A working MVP beats an ambitious idea with no demo.	Medium
Clarity	Is the writing clear? Does it follow the required sections? Judges read 25 proposals. Clear writing gets read properly.	Medium
Proof of client or lead	A real person or business that has the problem you're solving and can confirm it. Not required, but teams with this move ahead.	Strong advantage

The one move that separates shortlisted teams

Before you submit, find one real person or business that has the problem you are solving. It does not need to be a signed client. A business owner who confirms the pain, a LinkedIn conversation, a WhatsApp exchange, a Reddit thread from someone in the industry. Attach it with your submission.

Teams that submit proof of a real potential client or lead get a significant advantage in the shortlist decision. The problem stops being theoretical.

Talk to people in the industry you are targeting. LinkedIn outreach works. Local businesses are faster than you think. Discord and Reddit communities exist for nearly every vertical.

Ask one question: do you actually have this problem and would you pay to solve it? They do not need to commit to anything. You just need to show the problem is real.

5. Stage 2 - Top 10 Shortlisted

After proposals close on May 31, judges review all 25 submissions and select 10 teams to move forward. Results are announced on June 7.

The decision is based on the six criteria above. Problem quality, proxy depth, product potential, and feasibility all factor in. Teams with verified client or lead proof carry a clear edge when scores are close.

If you do not make the top 10, proposal feedback will be available. The judges are looking for founders who think clearly, not just developers who build fast.

6. Stage 3 - Elevator Pitch Video (Top 10 Only)

Every team in the top 10 submits an elevator pitch video. This is mandatory. Teams that do not submit a video by June 21 are removed from the competition.

The video goes live on Torch Labs and {PROXY}Maze'26 social channels. The team that gets the most impressions, likes, comments, and shares wins the Most Popular Project Award. The winner is announced on Grand Final day, July 12.

Format requirements

- Under 2 minutes total
- 16:9 horizontal, minimum 1080p, MP4 format
- Clear voiceover or readable captions
- Leave safe space around the edges for the Torch Labs logo frame. Do not put key content in the corners or near the top and bottom edges.
- English, Sinhala, or Tamil accepted. Include English captions if you use Sinhala or Tamil.

Recommended structure

Section	Suggested time
Open strong: grab attention, say who you are	5 to 10 sec
The problem: who has it and what does it cost them	20 to 25 sec
Market size: how many people have this problem	15 to 20 sec
Your solution: what you built and how it works	25 to 30 sec
Torch Labs proxy usage: why proxies are central to the product	10 to 15 sec
Current progress: what is working, what is next	15 to 20 sec
Close: one clear statement about where this goes	5 to 10 sec

What makes a strong video

Show a real problem, not a feature list. The viewer should understand within 20 seconds who is suffering and why.

Include at least one form of visual proof: a screen recording, a live demo clip, a Figma mockup, a dashboard preview. A talking head video with no visuals will not hold attention.

The proxy section matters. Say clearly which Torch Labs product you are using and what breaks without it.

7. Stage 4 - Grand Final (July 12, 2026)

All 10 teams pitch in person. Each team gets 12 minutes: 8 to present and demo, 4 for judge questions. No exceptions on timing.

The Most Popular Project Award is also announced on Grand Final day. It goes to the team whose elevator pitch video received the most engagement on social channels.

Present the six sections below in exactly this order. Teams that skip sections or rearrange them lose points on presentation score.

Section	What to cover	Status
01 The Problem	Name the industry and the workflow. Show the pain with a quote or data point from your customer discovery. Specific problems score. 'Companies need data' does not.	Required
02 Target Customer	A job title, an industry, a company size. The more specific, the better. Judges want to know you understand who pays.	Required
03 Product Demo	Live or recorded walkthrough of your working MVP. Real proxy requests, real data, solving the stated problem. Most watched part of the pitch.	Required
04 Proxy Architecture	How Torch Labs proxies are integrated. Tier, session type, geo routing. What breaks if you remove the proxy layer.	Required
05 Market Value	How large is the problem? What do people currently pay for alternatives? Numbers help.	Required
06 Business Model	Who pays? How much? What does Torch Labs proxy cost relative to what a customer pays? Name a pricing model.	Required

The demo is the most important part

Working prototype and demo quality is weighted at 4x and worth 20 points. A live demo with real data, where the customer use case is obvious without narration, scores at the top. Screenshots score at the bottom.

If your product makes real proxy requests against a live target, show it on screen. The UI can be rough. What judges need to see is that the core pipeline works end to end.

Customer discovery is required for all teams

Every team must bring at least one customer discovery artifact to the Grand Final. A screenshot of a conversation, a call summary, a LinkedIn thread, a voice note transcript. Someone who works in your target industry confirmed the problem is real.

Teams presented without a discovery artifact are penalised in scoring. This is the minimum bar.

8. Torch Labs Proxy Products

Torch Labs will provide all shortlisted teams with access to our residential and ISP proxy products for the duration of Challenge 2. You do not need to arrange access yourself.

Category	What it is	When to use it
Residential Proxies	Rotating residential IPs from real devices. High trust level across standard to high-detection targets. Suitable for most scraping, data collection, and browser automation use cases.	Most products built for data access, AI browsing, or workflow automation.
ISP Proxies	Static IPs assigned by internet service providers. Combines residential trust with datacenter-grade stability. Best for workflows requiring sustained sessions or consistent geo-presence.	Products that need sticky sessions, repeated logins, or stable long-running connections to the same target.

In your proposal, you must state which product category you need: residential, ISP, or both. You must also state whether you need any additional support from Torch Labs, for example guidance on proxy integration, session configuration, or geo-targeting. Teams that are clear about their requirements will get faster access and better support.

9. Submission Checklists

Before your proposal (May 31 deadline)

- Track confirmed and written in Section 1
- Problem statement names an industry, a role, and a specific cost in time or money
- Proxy section explains what breaks without proxies and which tier you need
- Business case names a paying customer and a price
- Scope is honest about what will be done by July 12
- Proxy product category stated: residential, ISP, or both
- Additional support requirements from Torch Labs stated, or confirmed as none
- Proof of client or lead attached (not required, but strongly recommended)
- Saved as PDF, named your_team_name.pdf, 2 pages or under

Before your video (June 21 deadline)

- Under 2 minutes
- 16:9, 1080p minimum, MP4
- Covers all seven sections in the recommended structure
- Includes at least one visual demo or screen recording
- Key content not in corners or near the top and bottom edges
- Voiceover is clear or captions are readable

Before the Grand Final (July 12)

- All six pitch sections ready in the required order
- Live demo ready with real data and real proxy requests
- Customer discovery artifact available to reference or show
- Business model numbers you can speak to without slides
- Proxy architecture you can explain technically when judges probe

Questions

Reach out to the organising team. Questions about proxies, judging, product scope, track selection, or eligibility are all fine. A question asked before submission is better than a misunderstanding after.